His profile remained in focus during a consultative meeting of delegations from sixty-five communist and workers' parties in Budapest on 28 February 1968, where he proclaimed solidarity with the 'most profoundly just struggle' for freedom by the Vietnamese people. 'The events in Vietnam, Korea, the Near East, Yemen and Greece and the renazification in West Germany, disclose the plans of the main imperialist powers to achieve their aggressive aims with the help of numerous so-called 'limited' wars.'16 When the applause died down, he railed against the FRG's 'revanchist and expansionist policy of providing the natural breeding ground for renazification, which has now become crassly apparent'.17

Against this background, Honecker's attention was firmly focused on Czechoslovakia, where, a week earlier, Alexander Dubček, the youthful new Communist Party leader, had loosened government control and expanded individual rights, giving hope to Czechs, and angering the USSR.